

6: Structures and Organizations

Introduction

So far, our journey through the foundational concepts in sociology has taken us through [meaning](#)—the significance that the world holds for us—and [interaction](#)—how those meanings emerge from cues we see in the world around us and in other people. I have also emphasized the increasing complexity of society,¹ which is to say, the now nearly-overwhelming set of meanings and interactions that are available to you, as a member of a Contemporary Industrial Society.

¹ In my discussion of [cultural development](#) in human societies.

Structures

The combination of the importance of meanings and interactions and their proliferation in complex societies begs the question: how are meanings and interactions *organized*? To put this more concretely, think of your commute to campus (or, if you live on campus, your walk to the lecture hall for class).² As you take every step (if you're walking) or make every turn (if driving) or wait for your delayed LIRR train (if taking public transit), consider how *difficult* that step in your journey would be if you couldn't rely on other people's behavior being at least somewhat *predictable*.

² You can substitute nearly any task you need to accomplish in your daily life, if you prefer.

Now, I don't mean that you know every single thing that each individual person you meet is going to do. Instead, I mean that you can say to yourself, for instance

I am on a train. I can expect that, if I keep my headphones in and focused on my phone, the only direct interaction I will have is when the conductor checks my ticket. Anything else is an unusual interaction.³

or

I am driving to campus on Nicholls road. That means that many people around me will be driving far above the speed limit, but if I stay comfortably in the slow lane, I can listen to a podcast as I drive.

or

I am leaving my dorm and have not yet eaten. However, since it's the middle of the semester on a Tuesday, I can plan to pick something up from the food trucks by the SAC or walk over to Druthers for a muffin.

The point here is that your experience would become unmanageable, and social life would grind to a halt, if you couldn't rely on these kinds of expectations in your daily life.⁴ But, overwhelmingly, you *can* count on these patterns of interaction and significance to exist, and sociologists refer to such patterns as **social structures**.

Groups

Activity to demonstrate small groups: get each person to say who they're sitting next to, and also who they know best in the class. Make a network diagram to show the difference between an assembly and a group.

- Primary group
- Secondary group
- Reference group

³ For those of you scoring at home, yes, this is an example of *civil inattention* from our discussion of [interaction](#)!

⁴ More technically, this is a *functionalist* argument for the necessity of basic social organization.

A **social structure** is a pattern of significance that endows interactions with (at least minimal) predictability.

The Power of Groups

From small group analysis/Asch, demonstrate the kinds of coercion a group can exhibit.

Organizations

Small groups and formal organizations.

The Power of Organizations

Demonstrate the necessity and power of formal organizations in the modern world to categorize and control people.

Contemporary Dynamics

The "network society". Social capital analysis.